ordered complexity, the harmonised multiplicity, the many in one which is the clue to the structure of the universe'.[1] That sounds almost admirable, till one understands that this complexity, in practice, ossified into impermeable social barriers that manifested themselves in degrading forms of social discrimination and economic oppression. It was not always the case: there was a famous 'fuzziness' to the operations of caste in the pre-colonial era, and many famous examples of caste mobility (beyond those of Veda Vyasa and Valmiki). Be that as it may, the workings of caste extended into religious worship as well. Many temples forbade entry of the 'lower' castes and the 'outcastes'; the latter became known as 'Untouchables' because of the innumerable social prohibitions and indignities to which they were subject.

There is no excusing such abhorrent practices, and many modern Hindus have grown up rejecting the discriminatory aspects of the caste system, while still observing caste preferences when it comes to arranging the marriages of their children. Their logic is simple: caste is a form of community organisation that has been in place for ever, and we are not about to jettison it. We are comfortable with the affinities it implies, and we would prefer to perpetuate our family by arranging marriages within our caste group. But that doesn't mean we will discriminate against people of other castes, or mistreat them: we are educated people, and we know that's wrong. This may strike many modern Indians as a dubious compromise, but the attitude I have summarised is far more common within the Hindu population than many imagine.

It should also be said that the most impressive of India's movements against caste discrimination, from those of Basava in the twelfth century to Sree Narayana Guru in the nineteenth, came from within Hinduism and retained a Hindu vocabulary and conceptual world, including reverence for Hindu deities. Sree Narayana Guru, forbidden as an Ezhava from worshipping at the Shiva temple, entered a river and unearthed a *lingam* (phallic statue) that he consecrated himself, thereby creating his own Shiva rather than rejecting the god who was denied to him. The fourteenth-century Bhakti saint Chokhamela was a Dalit whose fervour for God continued even though he was not allowed inside the